

Supping With the Junta

Even as the cry for democracy rings out in Yangon, a pragmatic India sides with the Generals to safeguard its strategic interests



FREEDOM MARCH: At least three monks were killed in Yangon

Not far from the world's largest democracy, on India's eastern flank, there was little to cheer last week as democracy was muzzled by Myanmar's military junta, which mounted a massive crackdown on thousands of Buddhist monks who were marching down the streets of Yangon, the capital, staging protests in support of Aung San Suu Kyi, the pro-democracy leader who has been under military detention for the past 10 years. At least three monks have reportedly been killed in the clashes.

As the events unfolded in the neighbourhood, India faced a strategic dilemma. It had three choices: sit back and be nothing more than a curious onlooker; join the bandwagon of the US—India's new strategic partner — which had dubbed the developments in Yangon a threat to the security of South-east Asia; or act in its own interest, shunning its traditional stance as cheerleader for democracies around the world. It chose the third option. The protests in Yangon notwithstanding, Petroleum Minister Murli Deora had to cut short his Sunday bridge ses-

sion and dash off to Yangon on September 23 on a strategic mission to ink an energy deal for exploration of three offshore blocks on the Rakhin coast of Myanmar by ONGC Videsh.

As Deora met his counterpart Brigadier General Lyn Thi and offered him a package for modernisation of refineries and training of personnel, the issue of energy security at home was at the back of his mind, with China attempting to overtake India in this

regard. Myanmar, with its strategic location and oil reserves—its annual oil production is pegged at 50 million barrels—can play a pivotal role in India's energy security strategy. Deora's visit at a time when Myanmar was mired in protests points to India's strategic intent. It aimed at making up for the setback over China ejecting India in a major gas deal recently. In a political decision by the military to sidestep India's claims of being a 'preferential buyer' on the A1 and A3 blocks of its offshore natural gas fields, where India has a 20 per cent stake, Yangon had awarded the deal to China even though the Chinese offer was less competitive.

While the human rights situation in Yangon should be a cause for concern, India's real interest lies in countering the Chinese influence by ensuring that Myanmar continues to deliver on its commitment to its energy security initiatives. From being a vociferous supporter of Suu Kyi till the early 1990s, India has reversed its policy, sensing that supporting the rulers in Yangon serves its look-East policy. India's foreign office has expressed hope that all sides in Myanmar "will be able to resolve their issues peacefully through dialogue". For now, it makes sense to help the Generals by providing them light helicopters, military hardware, training and even counter-insurgency packages of arms and ammunition. Myanmar, in turn, has helped India deal with insurgency by taking action against north-eastern militant groups operating from its territory.

A clear indication of the objectivity of India's foreign policy, Deora's visit proves that India, which has constantly opposed western double-standards on Myanmar, has not mortgaged its neighbourhood relations to the US. "They overlook what happens in Pakistan, but point fingers at India for co-habiting with the Generals," remarks an MEA official. But beyond its current engagement with Myanmar, India will need a change of gear if it has to leverage the influence it has cultivated with the Generals. With China offering to buy influence for Yangon at the UN Security Council and ASEAN, Delhi will have to intensify its strategy for addressing its energy and security concerns.

by Saurabh Shukla

WHAT IS AT STAKE

- Myanmar's vast oil and gas reserves can meet a big chunk of India's demand of 2.8 million barrels per day.
- Its location as the gateway to ASEAN countries is important for India's look-East policy.
- Myanmar's support is vital for curbing insurgency along the 1,680-km border in the North-east.